

Measuring the credibility of generative AI-produced information: An exploratory factor analysis

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Abstract

Information credibility is a central concept in information science research and is closely linked to how people evaluate and use information. Credibility perceptions also play an important role in the adoption and continued use of technologies such as generative AI (gen AI). As gen AI becomes increasingly integrated into everyday life, it is essential to understand how people perceive the credibility of information produced by these systems. As part of a larger survey study on the use (and non-use) and perceptions of gen AI in higher education conducted in mid-2024 and mid-2025, we evaluated a set of questionnaire items to assess the *perceived credibility of information* created by gen AI. In this paper, we present the questionnaire items, descriptive statistics, and correlation matrices from the two surveys, and the results of our exploratory factor analysis examining the underlying structure of the credibility measure. Across both datasets, we identified two distinct factors—*output credibility*, which refers to the perceived credibility of AI-produced output itself, and *relative credibility*, which refers to perceptions of AI-produced output relative to human-produced information. We share the instrument and findings to support future refinement and adaptation in studying credibility in the context of gen AI.

CCS Concepts

• **Applied computing** → *Education*; • **Information systems** → *Users and interactive retrieval*.

Keywords

Generative AI, use, higher education, survey, knowledge workers

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1 Introduction

As generative AI (gen AI) systems increasingly act as intermediaries in knowledge production, understanding how people judge the credibility of the gen AI output has become a pressing issue. Emerging research has explored credibility in the context of gen AI across domains such as marketing [18], healthcare [32], and communication [5]. These studies identify factors including quality, timeliness, relevance, and consistency as influencing perceived credibility of gen AI output, and argue that credibility plays an important role in user trust and adoption. A recent qualitative study [6] identified nine constructs college students use to assess the credibility of gen AI output, including three (refinedness, human-likeness, and explainability) that appear unique to AI-mediated interactions. However, few studies have systematically developed or examined theory-informed instruments to assess credibility specific to the context of evaluating gen AI output.

Established credibility frameworks were developed in contexts where the author or source was identifiable and cues were explicit [13, 28]. Although much of this foundational work remains relevant, the dynamic, conversational, and adaptive nature of AI systems may call for revising how credibility is interpreted and assessed. Wang et al. [34] also noted that the affordances of gen AI, such as human-like reasoning and natural language fluency, raise new challenges for calibrating trust. To this end, we developed a survey items specifically designed to assess the perceived credibility of gen AI output drawing from a well-established credibility framework [13] and recent work on AI trust [1] and adoption [24]. In this paper, we report findings from an exploratory factor analysis of credibility-related items in this new gen AI context. The survey was part of a multi-year study on the perception and use of gen AI in a large research-intensive university [9].

This paper makes several contributions. First, it provides a quantitative examination of how credibility judgments are structured in the context of evaluating gen AI output. Second, the study is situated in higher education, where a rapid adoption of gen AI raises questions about academic integrity, critical thinking, and the evaluation of information. Finally, our findings identify two underlying factors of credibility, including one reflecting respondents' comparisons between AI- and human-generated output. Together, these contributions provide an initial empirical basis for developing a reliable, theory-informed instrument to assess the credibility of gen AI output.

2 Related Work

Credibility has long been a central construct in information science. It is typically conceptualized as a multidimensional judgment that involves trustworthiness (i.e., perceived integrity and fairness of a source) and expertise (i.e., perceived knowledge and competence of a source) [13, 30]. Prior research also distinguishes between source credibility (i.e., judgments about the trustworthiness and expertise of the information provider) and message credibility (i.e., the perceived accuracy and quality of the information itself) [14]. In information science, credibility has been studied as a key criterion in relevance judgments influencing how individuals select, accept, or reject information during information seeking and retrieval [31].

Credibility is viewed as socially and contextually constructed process that is influenced by individuals' prior knowledge, experience, and heuristics applied across different media and information types [13]. Credibility judgments are also mediated by factors such as characteristics of information objects [29], domain knowledge [21], technological affordances [33], the platform or medium through which information is sought [19], and social endorsement cues [27]. Assessing credibility is fundamental to users' ability to discern the quality and value of information, particularly in contexts such as health information seeking, misinformation evaluation, and everyday online searching [10, 27, 30, 31].

Measuring credibility: Information and message credibility have been measured using a wide range of approaches, from single- [2, 23] and multi-item surveys to attempt to differentiate between formative and reflective indicators of credibility [3]. Appelman and Sundar [3] developed and validated a message credibility scale in the context of online news, identifying 10 formative indicators (e.g., clear, complete, concise, consistent, objective) and three reflective indicators (e.g., accurate, authentic, and believable). Majerczak and Strzelecki [22] examined credibility in the context of online information verification on social media, using four items related to credibility, relevance/accuracy, trustworthiness, and completeness as part of their structural equation modeling to ascertain the factors that have the strongest influence on the information verification behaviors. Other studies have used accuracy, authority, objectivity, currency, and coverage as five dimensions to examine how web users (e.g., college students, general adults) perceive and verify information on the internet [11, 12, 25, 28].

Factor analysis has been widely recognized as an approach to examine the dimensions of credibility. Several studies used exploratory factor analysis to explore the underlying construct structure of credibility (e.g., [7, 16]), while others applied confirmatory factor analysis to test a hypothesized structure of credibility (e.g., [3, 17, 20]). Regardless of the factor analysis approach, the identification and inclusion of dimensions of certain credibility depend on researchers' conceptual justification [26]. In the current paper, we used exploratory factor analysis to examine how credibility constructs load in the evaluation of gen AI output.

Credibility in the age of AI: Credibility or its constituent aspects as identified by Hilligoss and Rieh [13] has been examined in studies of gen AI across various contexts, including marketing [18], healthcare [32], and communication [5]. Chakraborty and Biswal [5] surveyed active ChatGPT users and found that the perceived

Table 1: Credibility items.

#	Item text and source/inspiration
The information I get from gen AI technology and tools is...	
(1)	accurate [13]
(2)	trustworthy [13]
(3)	believable (2025 only) [13]
(4)	objective [13]
(5)	reliable [13]
(6)	up-to-date [32]
(7)	complete [24]
(8)	detailed (2025 only) [24]
(9)	relevant (2025 only) [24]
(10)	as good as a highly competent person could produce on their own [1]
(11)	as good as I could produce on my own

quality, timeliness, relevance, and consistency of output significantly predicted credibility. In a qualitative study, Choi et al. [6] found that college students assess the credibility of gen AI output by factors such as correctness, pertinence, explainability, and human-likeness. While prior studies explore factors affecting perceived credibility of gen AI output, few have systematically tested measures suited to evaluating such credibility in higher education and professional settings.

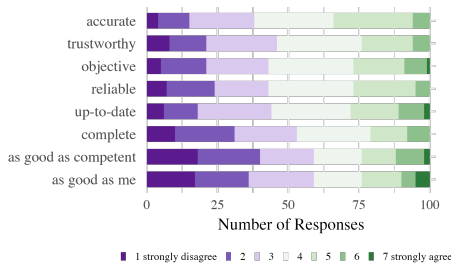
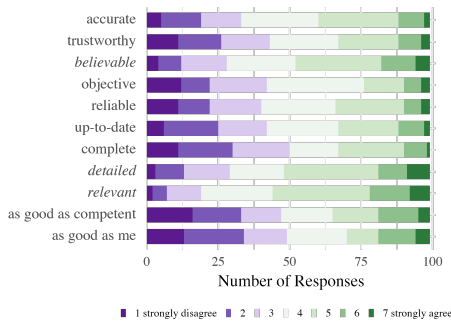
3 Method

We evaluated the perceived credibility of information generated by gen AI tools as part of a larger project [9] investigating the use and perceptions of gen AI in higher education using surveys administered to faculty and staff at a research-intensive university in mid-2024 ($n=102$) and mid-2025 ($n=101$).

Table 1 shows the credibility questionnaire items and the credibility literature in which they were grounded. Five items were created from the 5 constructs in Hilligoss and Rieh [13]: *truthfulness/accuracy*, *trustworthiness*, *believability*, *objectivity*, and *reliability*. We also added several items that have been used as measures of information quality, credibility, or trust in empirical studies including *completeness* [3, 24], *relevance* [24], *detail*, *currency* [32], and *relative to information produced by experts* [1] and *oneself*. To focus respondents on credibility of the information (vs. gen AI tool/source), items were preceded by the stem: "The information I get from gen AI technology and tools is..."

Exploratory Factor Analysis (EFA) models were estimated in Stata 19 and guided by [4, 8, 15]. Separate EFA models were run for 2024, 2025, and a subset of 2025 data, and results were compared. Factor analysis suitability was indicated by a statistically significant Bartlett's Test for Sphericity (2024: $\chi^2(28)=645.52$, $p<.001$; 2025 subset: $\chi^2(55)=776.668$, $p<.001$; 2025: $\chi^2(55)=1080.10$, $p<.001$) and a Kaiser-Meyer-Olkin Measure of Sampling Adequacy (KMO) greater than .75 (2024: .887; 2025 subset: .900; 2025: .913).

We used principal factors using polychoric correlation matrices using an oblique Promax rotation using Kaiser/Horst normalization to allow for correlation between extracted factors. As recommended

Figure 1: Credibility responses in 2024 survey ($n=100$).Figure 2: Credibility responses in 2025 survey ($n=99$).

by Costello [8], we ran several EFA models with the number of factors to extract set to the number indicated by parallel analysis and scree plots of the unrotated pattern matrix (i.e., 2 factors) and the number of expected factors during instrument development (i.e., 3 factors). We kept factors if at least 2 items had rotated pattern matrix loadings $> .4$ with minimal cross-loadings (i.e., loadings on a second factor $\leq .32$). We selected the 2-factor EFA models as they had less ambiguous factor loadings. Items were retained for a factor with item loadings $\geq .4$ (with no crossloads $> .32$) and communality $\geq .4$ (indicating the factors account for at least 40% of the observed variance in the item).

4 Results

Figures 1-2 and Table 2 show the distribution and descriptive statistics for responses to credibility-related items in 2024 and 2025.

On average, 2024 respondents indicated slight disagreement with all 8 credibility-related items, with stronger disagreement with statements that the information from gen AI is as good as a highly competent person could produce or they could produce. Similarly, 2025 respondents slightly disagreed with all of the same 8 statements as in 2024, including statements that the information from gen AI is as good as they or a highly competent person could produce (vs. slightly stronger disagreement in 2024). 2025 respondents indicated slight *agreement* with the 3 additional items added in 2025 (believable, detailed, relevant).

We found variability in the responses to *single survey item across respondents*, as demonstrated in the standard deviations and visually represented in Figures 1-2. We also found variability in responses of *single respondents across all items*. For example, in the 2025 data,

46 respondents agreed with at least one statement (i.e., 5-7) and disagreed with at least one statement (i.e., 1-3); and the average range of responses for an individual respondent was 2.47 ($SD=1.42$). Only 9 respondents provided the same response for all 11 items.

4.1 Exploratory factor analysis

We report the best fitting, two-factor EFA models estimated from the polychoric correlation matrix using principal factors. We estimated three sets of models: for the 8 items in the 2024 data, for the same 8 items in the 2025 data, and for all 11 items in the 2025 data. As shown in Table 3, all 3 EFA models had similar factor structures, item loadings, and factor correlations. We discuss each below.

For the 2024 data, six items loaded on Factor 1 which we label *output credibility*: the four credibility items derived from [13] (accurate, trustworthy, objective, reliable) plus up-to-date, and complete. Two items loaded on Factor 2 which we label *relative credibility*: these were the items that asked respondents to assess info from gen AI relative to human-produced information (as good as a highly competent person could produce, as good as I could produce).

The EFA of 2025 data with a subset of items showed very similar results. The same six items loaded on Factor 1 (*output credibility*) and the same two items loaded on Factor 2 (*relative credibility*). When all 2025 items were included, we found similar results. All five items derived from [13] loaded on Factor 1 (*output credibility*) and the same two items loaded on Factor 2 (*relative credibility*). Three items were not retained due to cross-loadings $> .32$.

Given consistency among the 3 EFA models, we created composite variables for *output credibility* and *relative credibility* that correspond to the unweighted average of scores retained items for Factors 1 and 2 as shown in bold text in Table 3 for 2024, 2025 (subset), and 2025. As shown in Table 4, unpaired t-tests that respondents gave significantly higher scores for output credibility than relative credibility for 2024 and 2025 but not for 2025 (subset).

Table 4: Output credibility and relative credibility composite variables: Mean, standard deviation, and paired t-test.

	output credibility <i>M (SD)</i>	relative credibility <i>M (SD)</i>	diff <i>p</i>
2024	3.62 (1.15)	3.24 (1.58)	.001
2025 (subset)	3.69 (1.35)	3.58 (1.70)	.35
2025	4.58 (1.58)	3.58 (1.70)	<.001

5 Discussion

In this paper, we describe the creation and preliminary assessment of an instrument to measure the perceived credibility of information produced by gen AI tools as part of a broader research project examining gen AI use and perceptions in higher education [9]. Instrument development was based on constructs from the unified framework of credibility [13] and supplemented with additions from empirical research on credibility and trust of gen AI [1, 24, 32].

Our preliminary assessment of the instrument indicates consistent results across surveys administered in 2024 and 2025. An exploratory factor analysis of data from both years revealed two

Table 2: Descriptive statistics and polychoric correlations for credibility-related items in 2024 survey ($n=100$) and 2025 ($n=99$). Unpaired t-tests showed no statistically significant differences between 2024 and 2025. See item text in Table 1.

#	2024		2024								2025		2025									
	desc. stats		correlations (polychoric)								desc. stats		correlations (polychoric)									
	M	SD	(1)	(2)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(10)	(11)	M	SD	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)	(10)
(1)	3.83	1.24	-								3.95	1.42	-									
(2)	3.55	1.31	.86	-							3.66	1.58	.91	-								
(3)	-	-									4.25	1.43	.79	.76	-							
(4)	3.68	1.35	.64	.68	-						3.59	1.48	.77	.86	.71	-						
(5)	3.58	1.33	.85	.84	.79	-					3.72	1.53	.90	.94	.73	.81	-					
(6)	3.73	1.39	.64	.74	.66	.75	-				3.72	1.48	.77	.73	.63	.64	.77	-				
(7)	3.35	1.42	.70	.67	.70	.79	.69	-			3.51	1.55	.80	.80	.74	.77	.78	.74	-			
(8)	-	-									4.32	1.49	.78	.69	.69	.61	.66	.63	.79	-		
(9)	-	-									4.56	1.33	.72	.66	.77	.66	.69	.68	.75	.81	-	
(10)	3.21	1.67	.70	.61	.53	.63	.56	.63	-		3.60	1.80	.68	.65	.61	.65	.70	.58	.71	.64	.71	-
(11)	3.27	1.67	.67	.66	.50	.66	.58	.66	.82	-	3.56	1.76	.62	.61	.53	.58	.66	.61	.68	.55	.59	.85

Table 3: Results of exploratory factor analysis. *Pattern matrix* for two factor solution with communalities (h^2), *eigenvalues* and *variance explained* (before rotation), and factor correlations. Bold indicates loadings > .6 without crossloadings > .32.

#	text (The information I get from gen AI technology and tools is...)	2024			2025 (subset)			2025		
		F1	F2	h^2	F1	F2	h^2	F1	F2	h^2
<i>pattern matrix</i>										
(1)	accurate	.63	.32	.79	.87	.09	.87	.87	.10	.89
(2)	trustworthy	.78	.16	.80	.98	-.02	.95	.99	-.04	.93
(3)	believable (<i>2025 only</i>)	-	-	-	-	-	-	.71	.17	.69
(4)	objective	.84	-.04	.66	.78	.12	.75	.78	.11	.73
(5)	reliable	.89	.08	.90	.88	.11	.91	.87	.09	.88
(6)	up-to-date	.73	.10	.65	.65	.20	.64	.62	.24	.64
(7)	complete	.63	.26	.69	.62	.32	.76	.59	.38	.80
(8)	detailed (<i>2025 only</i>)	-	-	-	-	-	-	.51	.39	.67
(9)	relevant (<i>2025 only</i>)	-	-	-	-	-	-	.43	.49	.72
(10)	as good as a highly competent person could produce on their own	.06	.85	.78	.12	.82	.82	.08	.85	.82
(11)	as good as I could produce on my own	.08	.83	.79	.07	.84	.79	.04	.83	.74
<i>eigenvalues</i>		5.58	.47		5.98	.51		7.97	.55	
<i>variance explained</i> (before rotation)		.92	.08		.92	.08		.89	.06	
<i>correlation</i> (F1, F2)		.69			.67			.69		

distinct factors that differentiate between *output credibility* and *relative credibility* of gen AI-produced information relative to human-produced information. We found knowledge workers in higher education to have higher perceptions of *output credibility* than perceptions of *relative credibility*. This suggests that while the gen AI-produced information is generally viewed as credible in its own right (e.g., appearing accurate, coherent), people were less confident when comparing it to information produced by humans.

When this survey was developed in early 2024, there were few existing surveys assessing the credibility of gen AI output, and little discussion on how credibility judgments in this context might differ from those of traditional online or social media content, given the

dynamic, conversational, and human-like nature of interactions. Our work addresses this gap.

Contributions of this work include the creation and analysis of theory-informed questionnaire items to measure credibility of gen AI-produced information, and the identification of *output credibility* and *relative credibility* in our exploratory factor analysis which was replicated across two surveys one year apart. This effort represents an early step toward conceptualizing and empirically measuring how people evaluate the credibility of AI-generated information. Limitations to this work include including only two items for assessing *relative credibility* and the addition of items in 2025 that were not included in the 2024 survey.

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